

PRODUCT STRATEGY DOCUMENT · HIKE RELAUNCH

# The Complete PM Journey.

*From live user research through to launch — the full path from Play Store friction to a feature WhatsApp is structurally unwilling to build.*

|                                    |                                                          |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| PREPARED FOR                       | SELECTED SOLUTION                                        |
| Hike Relaunch Hackathon            | Voice-to-Formal-English, for institutional communication |
| COMPANION DOCUMENT                 | STATUS                                                   |
| "The Letter Writer" – visual brief | Ready for build                                          |

NAVIGATION

## Table of Contents

The document follows the actual sequence of work: research first, then the opportunity tree it produced, then the job to be done, prioritisation, the requirements, the roadmap, the growth model, and finally how it's positioned, priced, and launched.

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SECTION 01

# User Research

Before any feature was chosen, the question was where WhatsApp actually hurts its own users. 58 live Google Play reviews of WhatsApp Messenger were pulled and read in full, then clustered into nine recurring friction themes.

## Methodology & a caveat

Reviews spanned roughly eighteen months of activity. "Helpful" vote counts were used only directionally, not as a ranking — an older review has had far longer to accumulate votes than one from last week, so frequency of independent mention mattered more than raw vote totals.

| Friction Theme                                                                  | Reviewers   | Severity                                        | Copyable by WhatsApp?                                             |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Account restriction / ban, no human appeal                                      | 9           | Very high — cuts off business & family contact  | Structurally hard — automated moderation at 3B-user scale         |
| Call quality & reliability                                                      | 7           | High                                            | Easily copyable — pure engineering                                |
| UI/UX churn from feature bloat (Channels redesign, forced Meta AI)              | 7           | High — erodes WhatsApp's own "simple" brand     | Structurally hard — Meta needs these surfaces for its own roadmap |
| Message / app reliability (sync, crashes, misdelivery)                          | 5           | High                                            | Easily copyable — bug fixes                                       |
| Backup, migration & storage                                                     | 5           | High — real data-loss fear                      | Partly structural — E2E backup has real trade-offs                |
| Identity tied to a phone number (privacy/security)                              | 3           | Low frequency, very high severity               | Structurally hard, <i>in theory</i> — see Section 02              |
| Login / session instability                                                     | 2           | High when it hits                               | Mostly copyable — bug fix                                         |
| Media send failures                                                             | 2           | Very high resonance (highest single vote count) | Easily copyable — bug fix                                         |
| Small feature gaps (logout button, DND mode, in-app browser, playback speed...) | ~9 mentions | Low–medium                                      | Trivially copyable                                                |

### THE FILTER THAT MATTERED

Four themes looked structurally defensible on first pass: account bans, feature bloat, phone-number identity, and backup/data portability. Everything else — call quality, sync bugs, media failures, small feature asks — is real pain, but WhatsApp will patch it. It's table stakes, not a moat.

## What secondary research changed

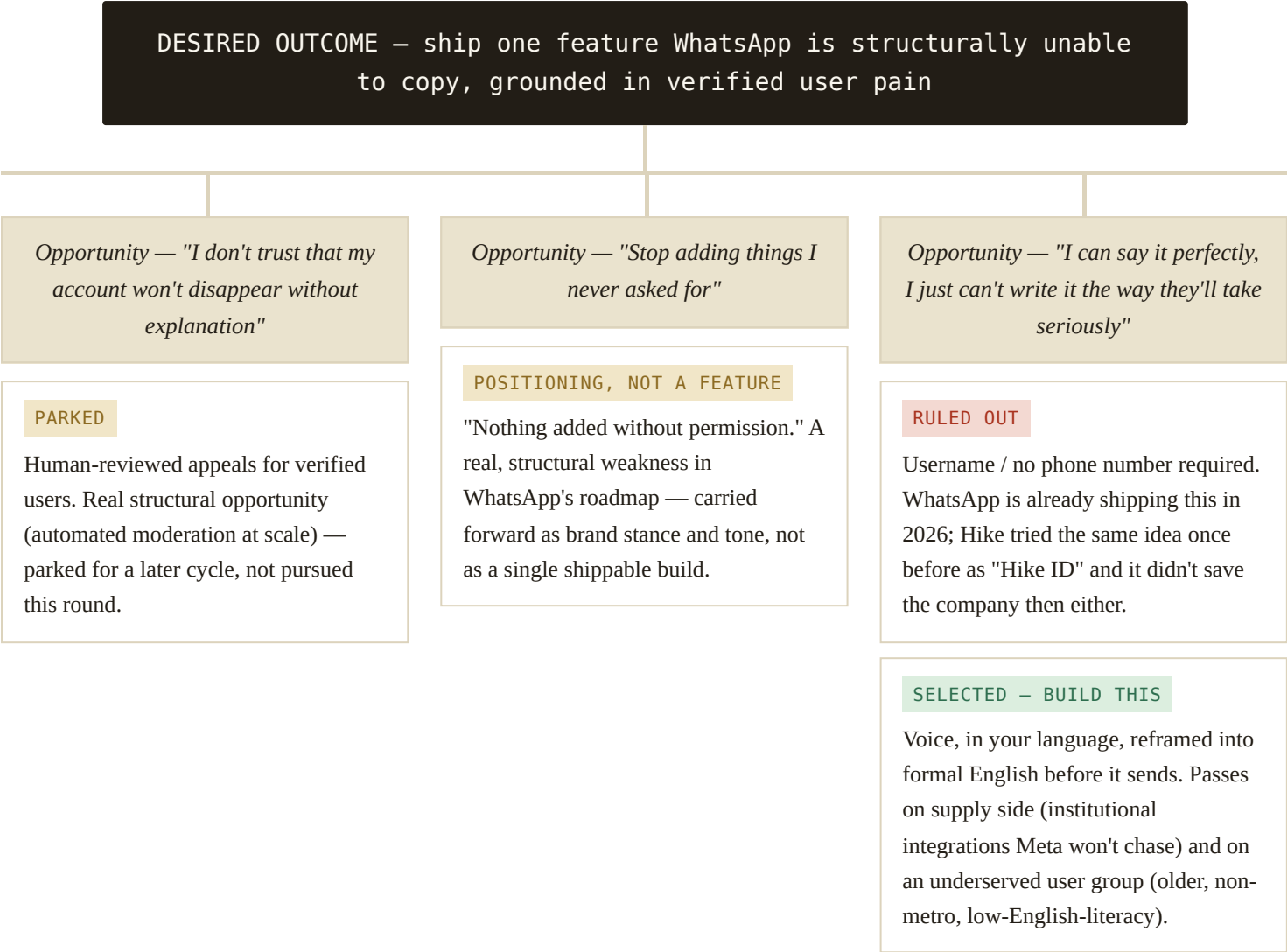
Live verification (not assumption) found that WhatsApp is already rolling out optional usernames through 2026 — making phone numbers optional to share — and already lets users hide their number inside Communities in beta. That directly disqualified the identity theme as a stand-alone moat. Separately, reporting confirmed the Meta AI backlash is real and structural: an unremovable AI icon wired into the search bar, described by users as "pointless and irritating," with Meta itself unable to offer an opt-out without undercutting its own AI roadmap.

This left one theme without a live disqualification: the gap between speaking a language confidently and writing formal English. The case study material on Hike's own history independently corroborated it — "Hike was right about language... a real, underserved need." That convergence is what carried this theme into the opportunity tree.

SECTION 02

# Opportunity Solution Tree

Outcome at the top, opportunities drawn from research, candidate solutions underneath — each one scored against the doc's five real moats: switching cost, regulation, a data network effect, a supply side, or a user group the incumbent won't serve.



## Assumptions this solution has to prove

- Speech-to-text accuracy on real, dialect-heavy, code-mixed speech is good enough that review-and-edit stays light, not a rewrite.
- At least one class of institution (starting with RWAs) will accept and act on a Hike-formalised message the same way they would a hand-written one.
- Users trust an AI-drafted formal letter enough to send it, once they've reviewed it themselves.

## SECTION 03

# Jobs To Be Done

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One underlying job, expressed across four situations. The job is never "translate my words" — it is "make sure I am taken seriously by someone who doesn't know me."

**PRIMARY JOB**

*When I need to write something formal in English but I'm not confident doing it myself, I want to speak naturally in my own language and get back a message that sounds like it was written by someone who knows how these things are written, so I can be taken seriously without depending on someone else being free and willing to help.*

**RESIDENT, HOUSING SOCIETY**

*When a maintenance issue or safety complaint keeps getting ignored, I want to send the committee something they can't dismiss, so my problem actually gets fixed, not just heard.*

**PARENT, SCHOOL WHATSAPP GROUP**

*When the school sends a formal notice, I want to reply in kind without sounding unable to help my own child, so I'm treated as an engaged parent, not a language barrier.*

**GIG WORKER**

*When a payment dispute needs to reach a client or platform support right now, I want to sound professional in the moment, so I don't lose the booking on top of the argument.*

**ELDER, FAMILY GROUP**

*When a government form or scheme application needs formal written English, I want to do it myself, so I'm not always waiting on my daughter to be free.*

## SECTION 04

## Prioritisation — RICE

Two passes. First, RICE cross-checks the opportunity tree's candidates against each other. Second, RICE decides which institutional vertical to build for first. Reach is per quarter, thousands of users; Impact follows the standard 3 / 2 / 1 / 0.5 / 0.25 scale; Confidence is a percentage; Effort is person-months against an 8-engineer team. All figures are planning estimates, not a forecast.

### 4.1 — Which feature to build

| CANDIDATE                             | REACH | IMPACT | CONFIDENCE | EFFORT | RICE |
|---------------------------------------|-------|--------|------------|--------|------|
| Username, no phone number required    | 500K  | 1      | 30%        | 2.0    | 75   |
| Hide phone number in Communities      | 150K  | 0.5    | 20%        | 1.0    | 15   |
| Voice → formal English, institutional | 200K  | 3      | 70%        | 3.0    | 140  |

Confidence is deliberately low for the first two: both are already shipping inside WhatsApp itself, which caps their realistic differentiation value regardless of Hike's own execution. The third wins on Impact and Confidence, not on raw reach.

### 4.2 — Which vertical to build first

| VERTICAL                                          | REACH | IMPACT | CONFIDENCE | EFFORT | RICE |
|---------------------------------------------------|-------|--------|------------|--------|------|
| Resident Welfare Associations (housing societies) | 80K   | 2      | 70%        | 1.5    | 74.7 |
| Schools (parent communication)                    | 60K   | 2      | 60%        | 2.0    | 36.0 |
| Gig platforms (dispute / client messages)         | 120K  | 1.5    | 50%        | 3.0    | 30.0 |
| Government / scheme portals                       | 40K   | 2.5    | 40%        | 4.0    | 10.0 |

RWAs win on high existing WhatsApp-group density, a single well-scoped integration surface, and residents who already trust the group as the channel of record. Schools and gig platforms are real Phase 2/3 expansions; government stays a Phase 3 pilot conversation, not a launch vertical.



## SECTION 05

# Product Requirements Document

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**Feature:** Voice-to-Letter — speak in any Indian language, review a formal English draft, send. **Owner:** Hike Product. **Target release:** Phase 1 pilot, RWA vertical.

## Problem statement

Users who speak confidently but don't write confident English have no reliable way to produce formal, institution-ready messages without depending on someone else. This blocks them from being heard by housing committees, schools, gig clients and government bodies — the moments that matter most.

## Goals

- Let a user go from spoken voice note to a sent, formal English message in under two minutes.
- Make the AI draft trustworthy enough that most users send it with light or no edits.
- Prove that a formalised message reaches and is acted on by a real institution (starting with one RWA pilot).

## Non-goals (v1)

- No support for languages outside the top Indian languages by speaker count at launch.
- No group-drafting or multi-party collaborative editing of a single message.
- No video or image-based input — voice and text only.
- No fully autonomous send — every message requires explicit user approval, permanently, not just at launch.

## User stories

*As a resident who isn't confident writing English, I want to record my complaint by voice, so that I don't have to struggle to type it myself.*

*As a user reviewing an AI draft, I want to see exactly what will be sent and edit any part of it, so that I stay in control of my own words.*

*As an RWA committee admin, I want to receive formal messages through the same WhatsApp group we already use, so that I don't have to adopt a new tool.*

*As a returning user, I want my past formalised messages saved, so that I can reuse a template for a recurring issue.*

## Functional requirements

**FR-01** System shall accept voice input up to 3 minutes in the top launch languages (Hindi, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi at v1).

|       |                                                                                                                             |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FR-02 | System shall render an editable formal-English draft within 8 seconds of recording ending, under normal network conditions. |
| FR-03 | No message shall send without an explicit, separate user action after the draft is shown — no auto-send under any setting.  |
| FR-04 | Any edit the user makes to the draft shall be logged (with consent) as training signal for that language/dialect pair.      |
| FR-05 | Messages to an integrated RWA channel shall carry the sender's identity and a delivered/read status back to the sender.     |
| FR-06 | Users shall be able to save a sent message as a reusable template for recurring situations.                                 |

## Non-functional requirements

|        |                                                                                                                                                        |
|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| NFR-01 | Voice data is not retained beyond the processing needed to produce the draft, unless the user explicitly opts in to help improve accuracy.             |
| NFR-02 | Target $\geq 85\%$ of drafts sent with no or only minor edits, for each of the five launch languages, before that language is considered launch-ready. |
| NFR-03 | End-to-end pipeline (speak → draft shown) completes in under 8 seconds at the 90th percentile on a standard 4G connection.                             |
| NFR-04 | All voice and message data handling is reviewed against India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act before any government-portal integration.         |

## Success metrics

- Primary: percentage of AI drafts sent without edit (trust signal).
- Primary: number of formalised messages sent per active user per month.
- Secondary: number of institutional partners with a live integration.
- Secondary: conversion rate from free to a paid tier.

## Dependencies

Speech-to-text vendor (Whisper / Bhashini / AI4Bharat), an LLM API for translation and formal reframing, and at minimum one committed RWA pilot partner before Phase 1 exits.

## SECTION 06

# Roadmap

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Phase 1  
Weeks 0–2

## Prove it — one vertical, one city

Full voice → formal-English pipeline for the RWA complaint letter. Review-before-send live. 3–5 friendly societies in one metro, manual coordination, no institutional integration yet.

KPI: 50+ formalised messages sent · 70%+ sent without edit

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Phase 2  
Month 1–3

## Expand the template library and the city count

Add school and gig-platform formats. Scale to ~50 societies across two cities. First formal integration conversation with an RWA management platform (MyGate / NoBrokerHood / ApnaComplex class of partner).

KPI: 1 signed institutional pilot · Individual-Certified tier live

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Phase 3  
Month 4–9

## The moat goes live

Named institutional integrations live across RWAs and schools, gig-platform pilot underway, correction dataset compounding per dialect, all three pricing layers active, first government pilot conversation opened.

KPI: 3+ paid institutional accounts · positive contribution margin on Institutional tier

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SECTION 07

# AARRR Growth Funnel

Pirate metrics, mapped to what actually happens for a resident in a pilot society — from first hearing about Hike to paying for it.

|                                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                 |                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Acquisition</b>                                                                                                                                |                                                                                                                                 |                                                        |
| Sees a neighbour's Hike-formalised message land in the society WhatsApp group, or is introduced by the community champion / RWA platform partner. | Primary channel: organic pull-through inside an existing WhatsApp group, backed by embedded distribution through RWA platforms. | <b>TARGET</b><br>30+ new users / society / month       |
| <b>Activation</b>                                                                                                                                 |                                                                                                                                 |                                                        |
| Records and sends their first formalised message, and it's delivered into the society channel successfully.                                       | The "aha" is seeing spoken words come back sounding like something a committee will actually read.                              | <b>TARGET</b><br>60% of installs send msg 1 within 48h |
| <b>Retention</b>                                                                                                                                  |                                                                                                                                 |                                                        |
| Comes back to formalise a new message the next time something needs to be raised formally — not a daily-use habit, an as-needed one.              | Measured over a longer window than typical chat apps, matching the actual frequency of the job.                                 | <b>TARGET</b><br>≥1 message/month over 3 months        |
| <b>Referral</b>                                                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                 |                                                        |
| A neighbour asks "how did you write that so well?" after seeing the message in the group, and installs Hike themselves.                           | The channel is structurally visible, not incentivised — the product demonstrates itself in public by design.                    | <b>TARGET</b><br>0.4+ viral coefficient per society    |

# Revenue

|                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                   |                                                |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Pays per certified template as an individual, or the RWA itself subscribes to the institutional tier for priority delivery and an admin dashboard. | Two payers, two motions — individual pay-as-you-go, institutional recurring SaaS. | <b>TARGET</b><br>8–12% free-to-paid conversion |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|

## SECTION 08

# Positioning

For urban Indian residents, parents and gig workers who need to write formal English but aren't confident doing it, **Hike** is a messaging companion that turns a spoken voice note in any Indian language into a formal message you review and approve before it sends. Unlike WhatsApp, which treats every user's writing confidence as the same, Hike is built for the exact moment your words need to be taken seriously by someone who doesn't know you.

## THE PITCH, IN ONE LINE

*"Hike is how people who don't write confident English get taken seriously by the institutions they deal with."*

~~Not: "Hike has AI voice translation."~~

The AI is the mechanism; it is never the headline. Every piece of collateral, every demo, every pitch opens with a specific person's specific letter finally getting read — not with a model name or a feature list.

NOT A BETTER WHATSAPP

NOT A TRANSLATION APP

NOT A SUPER-APP

ONE JOB, ONE REGISTER: FORMAL

SECTION 09

# Pricing & Monetisation

Hike raised \$261M without ever deciding who pays. This document decides it before Phase 1, not after. Three layers, each answering a different "who pays."

| TIER                   | WHO PAYS                     | PRICE             | WHAT IT UNLOCKS                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Individual — Free      | No one                       | ₹0                | Unlimited basic voice-to-formal-text. The acquisition hook — it has to work for everyone, always.                               |
| Individual — Certified | The individual, occasionally | ₹5–15 / use       | Certified formats: RTI applications, tenancy notices, formal complaint letters with the correct legal/administrative structure. |
| Institutional — Small  | The RWA / school             | ₹999 / mo         | Verified receiving channel for societies under ~150 units — priority delivery, an admin dashboard, response tracking.           |
| Institutional — Large  | The RWA / school             | ₹2,999–4,999 / mo | Same, scaled for societies or school networks over ~500 members, with multi-admin access and analytics.                         |
| Public / CSR Pilot     | State or CSR budget line     | Custom, per pilot | Co-funded integration with a government grievance or scheme-application portal, framed as a digital-literacy initiative.        |

Illustrative pricing for planning purposes – validate against willingness-to-pay research in the first RWA pilots before Phase 2 pricing goes live.

Exhibit E, applied – the free tier stays free because it is the funnel, not the business. Individuals pay occasionally; institutions pay recurring; government pays per pilot. All three are decided now.

## SECTION 10

# Go-To-Market & Launch Strategy

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Beachhead: mid-to-large RWAs in Tier-1 Indian metros (Bangalore, Pune, Hyderabad) — dense WhatsApp-group usage already, a visible English-confidence gap among older residents, and an existing ecosystem of RWA management software to partner with rather than fight.

## Channels

### 1 Embed inside existing RWA platforms

Position Hike as the formal-communication layer inside MyGate, NoBrokerHood and ApnaComplex rather than a fifth app residents have to adopt separately — distribution through tools committees already pay for.

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### 2 Community champions

Recruit one resident per society — usually the existing WhatsApp group admin — as the first user and informal ambassador. They already have the social trust the product needs to spread.

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### 3 Native pull-through, not paid acquisition

Because the formalised message lands in the society's existing WhatsApp group, every neighbour who reads it sees the product working in public. "How did you write that so well?" is the acquisition loop — no ad spend required for the first thousand users.

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### 4 Sequence outward from trust, not from reach

Schools and gig platforms are bigger audiences but colder trust — they follow only once the RWA vertical has proof points (message volume, satisfaction, a working institutional integration) to point to.

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## Launch phases

- **Private pilot** — 3–5 hand-picked societies, founder-led onboarding, daily feedback loop. Success gate for the next phase.
- **Closed beta** — ~50 societies across two cities, first RWA-platform integration live, waitlist-gated sign-up to control support load.
- **City-wide open launch** — public sign-up in the first city, community-champion program formalised, press/PR around the RWA pilot's outcomes.
- **Multi-city expansion** — replicate the playbook in 2–3 more metros, begin school and gig-platform pilots in parallel.

## Launch readiness checklist

- ☐ Draft accuracy meets the 85% sent-without-edit bar for the top launch languages.



- ☐ At least one RWA pilot has agreed to receive Hike-formalised messages directly in its existing group.
- ☐ A plain-language privacy policy covering voice data handling is published and linked in-app.
- ☐ A support flow exists for a mistranslated or wrongly-formalised draft, before the user ever sends it.
- ☐ Pricing for the Individual-Certified tier is live and tested with real payment flow.

**GTM metrics to track:** weekly active formalisers per society, percentage of AI drafts sent with no edit (trust signal), institutional partner count, paid-tier conversion rate, and NPS specifically among self-identified low-English-confidence users.

SECTION 11

# Risks & Open Questions

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|                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ACCURACY             | Dialect and code-mixed speech (Benglish, Hinglish) carries higher transcription error rates than clean single-language input — precisely the users this is built for. Review-before-send is the mitigation, not a workaround to remove later. |
| COST & LATENCY       | Per-message API cost across speech-to-text and an LLM call needs real budgeting against the free tier before Phase 2 scale — this is where the freemium funnel meets margin reality.                                                          |
| PRIVACY              | Voice data handling needs a story that matches a product pitched on trust, and needs to account for India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act — especially before any government-portal integration in Phase 3.                            |
| INSTITUTIONAL TRUST  | RWA committees and school administrations move slowly and skeptically. The community-champion motion exists specifically to de-risk this — cold institutional outreach without a resident advocate is a much harder sell.                     |
| COMPETITIVE RESPONSE | If Meta ships a strong native "write this formally" assistant inside WhatsApp, the translation-quality edge narrows fast. The moat has to stay the institutional integrations and the correction dataset, never "our AI is better."           |

## SECTION 12

## Appendix & Sources

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- Companion visual brief: "*The Letter Writer*" — case history, opportunity tree, mechanism and architecture, published as an interactive artifact and as an 11-page PDF.
- Grounded in the Hike case study (founding through the September 2025 wind-down), live WhatsApp Google Play review research, and verified reporting on WhatsApp's 2026 username rollout (WABetaInfo) and Communities phone-number privacy beta (SamMobile, TechRadar).
- RICE scores, funnel targets, and pricing figures in this document are planning estimates. Replace with observed data from the Phase 1 RWA pilots before committing to Phase 2 budget.